

Illustration depicting Emperor Shah Jahan

The agreed-upon facts are straightforward. Shah Jahan (1592-1666) was the fifth emperor of the Mughal Empire, a mighty Muslim-ruled state that dominated most of today's northern India, Pakistan and Afghanistan until they were eclipsed and eventually destroyed by the British in the 18th century. Jahan was an ambitious man of royal lineage who came to the throne in 1628 through a combination of military conquest and adroit politicking, and during his reign he expanded the empire and accomplished a number of feats of city planning and monumental architecture (of which the Taj is only the most famous example). He ruled until he was deposed and imprisoned by his son Aurangzeb in 1658.